



He lacks in understanding the gap between objective reality and subjective preparation. That way, he is a flawed administrator.

KSHITI GOSWAMI
RSP leader and state
PWD minister



centralisation of power in villages through regular panchayat elections. But considering the fact that the land to man ratio is very low in Bengal, the good days could not last forever. A saturation level arrived and land was not profitable any longer. There was too little to cultivate for the growing masses who wanted more. By the mid-'90s, as economists point out, 13 per cent of villagers had sold their land and moved on to other businesses. It was important, indeed vital, for the state's survival to move on to the next best option as agriculture was not being productive enough.

It was then a few like Bhattacharya hit upon the idea of big industry without for once trying to understand how it worked. All these years, the CPI(M) formula of "small favours for the maximum" had worked to its advantage. "Smalltime villagers, peasants and even hawkers in the city depended on party bosses for small favours for survival. Nobody asked legal questions because nobody had the money to go to court. It was these smalltime neta-s who proved to turn into the creamy layer of the CPI(M), the middle-tier, which not only became corrupt, greedy but wanted to become creamier with a finger in every pie. The top rung, in most cases, had no control over this section.

Bhattacharya was and remains to this day one of those who believe that all is fair and good in this world and that is the chief reason for the demolition of his Brand Bengal," says political commentator and economist Abhirup Sarkar.

Good industry requires a level playing field. The CPI(M) middle-tier would have nothing of that. In Singur, where the Tatas pitched camp, the CPI(M) workers wanted more; in Nandigram, they actually occupied village after village with force, and even fought pitched battles leading to what we now know as a black chapter in the state's history. During the event, the leaders who lived in the cities completely bypassed the fortunes and lives of the peasants for whom there was nothing left but those small plots of land—land they would give their lives for. Nobody in the CPI(M) secretariat, even as late as in May this year when the state went for the Lok Sabha polls, actually understood that they had totally lost their biggest asset: the rural peasantry. "It was a monumental lack of vision of the top leadership of which I would believe Bhattacharya would be the most culpable. As the chief minister, he did not ensure



**MAMATA WAS HAILED
THE LEFT'S CAUSE
ON A PLATTER**

Mamata has become the counterpoint to the Marxists' rural hegemony.